THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Should You Still Want What the Torah Forbids?

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 6

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 6, and the opening of Chapter 7 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 26 March 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

The Rabbi opened with a short review. Chapter 1 set out the five faculties of the one soul. Chapter 2 showed that the Torah's commands are aimed mainly at the fourth faculty (desire and will), which is then carried out through the second (the senses and actions). Chapter 3 compared spiritual illness to physical illness, the worst case being the person who does not know he is ill. Chapter 4 was about the middle path and balance. Chapter 5 set the goal: everything we do, even rest and enjoyment, should be "for the sake of heaven".

Person A or person B?

Before reading the chapter, the Rabbi put a question to the class. Person A has a strong urge to steal. For years he fights it and never steals. Person B has worked on himself until he no longer has any wish to steal; he feels it is simply wrong. In their actions the two are identical. Which is the better person?

Opinions were divided. Some said A, because he is fighting a real battle. Others said B, because he has actually perfected himself. The Rabbi said the answer is B, and then gave strong sources for A.

The first is the Midrash quoted by Rashi at the end of Parashat Kedoshim: a person should not say "I have no wish to eat pork, I have no wish to wear shaatnez". He should say, "I would like to, but what can I do? My Father in heaven has forbidden it." The Rabbi put it in everyday terms: walking past a non-kosher restaurant, the ideal response is not "ugh" but "that smells delicious, and Hashem told me not to".

The second is the story of Abaye, who followed a man and a woman through the countryside for three parasangs to make sure they did not sin. When they parted innocently, he wept, saying that he himself could not have held back. He was told: whoever is greater than his fellow, his inclination is greater than his. Elsewhere Hazal say that the reward is according to the effort. All of this seems to praise the person who has the urge and controls it.

The philosophers and King Shelomoh

The Rambam opens the chapter with the philosophers. They distinguish the moshel benafsho, the person who exercises self-restraint, from the hasid, whose nature itself wants the good. The moshel benafsho does good things, but against the pull of his own heart. The hasid does good because he wants to. The philosophers all agree that the hasid is greater, because the one who restrains himself still has something in him that longs for evil.

The Rambam then shows that King Shelomoh says the same: "The soul of the wicked desires evil", and "It is joy to the righteous to do justice", while for wrongdoers it is a torment.

The Rabbi tied this back to Chapter 2. The Torah aims at the fourth faculty, our desires. Someone who only controls his actions has dealt with faculty two. Someone who has changed what he wants has dealt with the problem at its root. He mentioned that this is what we should be working on around the High Holy Days, not only adding good deeds.

So there seems to be a contradiction: the philosophers and Shelomoh praise the person with no urge, while Hazal seem to praise the person with the urge who holds back.

The Rambam's resolution

One suggestion from the class was that it is a process: you start with the struggle and grow towards wanting the good. The Rabbi liked it, but said it cannot explain why Hazal tell us to say "I would like to eat it".

The Rambam's answer, which he himself calls a wonderful idea, is that there are two kinds of misvot.

- **Rational misvot.** Things that reason alone tells us are wrong, which we would know even if the Torah had not written them: murder, theft, deception, harming someone who did you good, insulting your parents. Here the philosophers are right. If you still want to do these things, something in you is lacking, even if you never act on it.
- **Revealed misvot.** Things we know only because Hashem commanded them, which the Torah calls hukkim: meat and milk, shaatnez, and similar. Here Hazal are right. There is nothing wrong with wanting them. The only thing stopping you should be that Hashem said no.

The proof is in the wording of Hazal. They never said "a person should not say I have no wish to kill or to steal". Their examples are all from the revealed misvot.

The Rabbi reframed his opening question. Who is better: the person who longs to beat his parents and holds himself back, or the person who cannot imagine doing it after all they have given him? Put that way, everyone agrees.

Along the way he noted two points. The Rambam calls the rational misvot by the name "some of the later sages" gave them, sikhliyot, and adds that those sages caught "the illness of the Mutakallimun", the Arabic theologians of Kalam. He is referring to Rav Saadiah Gaon, who first used the terms. The Rambam accepts the categories but disliked how far Saadiah's thought was shaped by Kalam. Second, a hok for the Rambam is not a law without a reason. It is a law whose reason is hard to understand, and he objected strongly to the idea that some misvot have no reason.

His summary of the chapter: "Sometimes it's good to have an urge and to stop yourself. Sometimes it's better not to have any urge at all."

Questions from the class

Hazal's list also includes arayot, forbidden relationships. Are those rational or revealed? The Rabbi suggested there are two groups. Some, like adultery, are clearly wrong by reason; he called it a kind of theft, and said the Rambam would agree it is better to have no urge for it at all. Others, perhaps some cases of incest, might not have been known by reason alone, and those are the ones Hazal meant. He noted that Saadiah does list arayot among the rational misvot.

Another question was about Abaye himself. If his struggle was praised, does that mean the sin he feared was only a revealed one? The Rabbi said this is genuinely difficult and left it open.

The opening of Chapter 7: the veils

With ten minutes left, the Rabbi began Chapter 7, on nevuah. Since the aim of these chapters is human perfection, and the highest human level is prophecy, the Rambam asks how one reaches it and why there are different levels.

Hazal say some prophets saw Hashem from behind many veils (mehisot), some from behind few, and Moses from behind one, which was clear and shining: the aspaklaria hameirah.

The Rambam explains that there are two kinds of virtue and vice: of the intellect and of character. The vices of character include excess desire, arrogance, impatience, anger, brazenness and chasing money. Each deficiency is a veil. As Isaiah said, "Your iniquities have separated between you and your God."

The Rabbi asked which is non-negotiable for a prophet, intellect or character. One participant answered intellect, which he praised, adding that prophecy is a knowledge of God, so without a developed mind it cannot happen however good a person is. The Rambam requires all the intellectual virtues, but only most of the character virtues, together with the important ones.

This is how the Rambam reads "prophecy rests only on one who is wise, strong and wealthy". Wise is intellectual perfection. Strong is the one who conquers his inclination. Wealthy is the one who is content with his portion. Contentment is so important that Yaakov, grieving for Yosef, had no prophecy for twenty-two years. Arrogance also drives prophecy away, and anger too was mentioned. There is, as he put it, a hierarchy of character traits.

Summary

- The philosophers say the hasid who has no urge to do wrong is greater than the moshel benafsho who resists it; Hazal seem to say the opposite.
- The Rambam reconciles them: for rational misvot one should lose the desire; for revealed misvot (hukkim) it is fine to want, and to hold back only because Hashem commanded.
- For the Rambam, a hok has a reason that is hard to grasp, not no reason.
- Chapter 7 begins: the veils between a prophet and God are his intellectual and moral flaws.
- A prophet needs full intellectual perfection, most good middot, and the key ones such as contentment and humility.

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